

Two Samples, One Difference

AP Statistics · Unit 4 · Topic 4.6 · B: 2027-02-04 · E: 2027-02-08 · TEACHER KEY

CED TETHER

- **ENDURING UNDERSTANDING: UNC-3** — Probabilistic reasoning allows us to anticipate patterns in data.
- **Skills: 3.B** — Determine parameters for probability distributions. | **3.C** — Describe probability distributions. | **4.B** — Interpret statistical calculations and findings to assign meaning or assess a claim.
- **UNC-3.T** Determine parameters of a sampling distribution for a difference in sample means. [Skill 3.B]
- **UNC-3.T.1** For a numerical variable, when randomly sampling from two independent populations with means μ_1 and μ_2 and standard deviations σ_1 and σ_2 , the sampling distribution of the difference in sample means has mean $\mu = \mu_1 - \mu_2$ and standard deviation $\sigma = \sqrt{\sigma_1^2/n_1 + \sigma_2^2/n_2}$. **UNC-3.T.2** If sampling without replacement and sample sizes are less than 10% of population sizes, the difference is negligible.
- **UNC-3.U** Determine whether a sampling distribution of a difference in sample means can be described as approximately normal. [Skill 3.C]
- **UNC-3.U.1** The sampling distribution of the difference in sample means can be modeled with a normal distribution if both population distributions can be modeled with normal distributions. **UNC-3.U.2** If population distributions cannot be modeled with normal distributions, the sampling distribution can be approximated by a normal distribution if both sample sizes are at least 30.
- **UNC-3.V** Interpret probabilities and parameters for a sampling distribution for a difference in sample means. [Skill 4.B]
- **UNC-3.V.1** Probabilities and parameters for a sampling distribution for a difference of sample means should be interpreted using appropriate units and within the context of specific populations.

Essential question: How can two sample means use different pathways to justify one normal model for their difference?

DOK-3 skill: 4.B · **FRQ pattern:** two-shape-routes-for-a-mean-difference

DOK rationale: Part (c) coordinates a separate shape pathway for each sample mean, judges two incomplete model claims, and uses a small-sample counterfactual to trace when the tail probability loses support.

First take → rules + (a)–(c) → turn in

DOK: 1 → 3

Minutes: 45

Teacher does

- Board slide up at the bell. Ask which details govern the sampling model.
- At minute 5, read the rules box aloud once; students start (a).
- Return at minute 33. Require separate shape arguments and the counterfactual check.
- Collect at the door. Score part (c) only, E/P/I.

Students do

- Name one argument to retain and one that needs more evidence.
- Read the rules box, work (a)–(c), revise the first take, and turn in.

Questions to ask

- Which distribution are we justifying for North: individual waits or sample means?

- Why can the two groups use different routes to approximate normality?
- What changes if the skewed South sample has size 8?
- What repeated-sampling event does 0.0273 describe?

Adult role

Solo teacher. Justify North and South separately, then combine them using independence.

[WARN] LOOK FOR

- Requiring both samples to have size at least 30 even when one population is normal.
- Assuming one normal component automatically fixes an unjustified second component.
- Subtracting variances because the statistic subtracts means.

SCORING PART (c) — E / P / I

Expected elements

- **judgment-1** (required) — Supports the original probability using North population normality and South $n=48$ CLT route.
- **judgment-2** (required) — Uses independence and explains the incomplete reasoning in both accounts.
- **judgment-3** (required) — Uses the 48-plus-8 counterexample: total 56 does not justify the small skewed South component.

E	Meets all three checks with correct contextual reasoning; equivalent wording is acceptable.
P	Shows at least one substantive correct check, but has an omission or error that prevents E.
I	Shows none of the three checks with substantive correct reasoning; a choice alone is insufficient.

[STAR] TODAY'S PROBLEM — annotated

Suppose parcel pickup waits have the shown population parameters, measured in minutes. There are 600 North visits and 1,000 South visits. North waits are approximately normal; South waits are strongly right-skewed. Independent SRSs are taken without replacement, and the service wants $P(\bar{X}_N - \bar{X}_S > 2.5)$.

Rina: “South is skewed, so I would not use a normal model for the difference.”

Oscar: “North is normal and the combined sample size is 60, so the normal model is valid; the probability is 0.0273.”

Locker samples

Locker	n	μ	σ
North	12	6.0	1.8
South	48	4.8	3.0

FIRST TAKE (5 min)

Would you check each place's sample size separately or add them together? Give one reason from the study.

Key: Not graded. Each account contains a claim that still needs component-level justification.

Rules callout “JUSTIFY EACH SAMPLE MEAN BEFORE THEIR DIFFERENCE (keep on the page)” is printed on the student sheet.

DOK 1 (a) State the mean of $\bar{X}_N - \bar{X}_S$ and translate the event above into context.

Key: The sampling distribution is centered at $\mu_N - \mu_S = 6.0 - 4.8 = 1.2$ minutes. The event says the sample mean North wait exceeds the sample mean South wait by more than 2.5 minutes.

DOK 2 (b) Verify both 10 percent conditions, compute the sampling-distribution SD, and calculate the probability under a normal model.

Key: North: $12 \leq 0.10(600) = 60$; South: $48 \leq 0.10(1,000) = 100$. The SD is $\sqrt{1.8^2/12 + 3.0^2/48} = \sqrt{0.4575} = 0.676387$. Thus $z = (2.5 - 1.2)/0.676387 = 1.92198$ and the upper-tail probability is $0.027304 \approx 0.0273$.

DOK 3 (c) In 4–5 sentences, decide whether 0.0273 is supported and explain what each student overlooks. Justify each sample mean using its own shape and size. Then consider $n_N = 48$ and $n_S = 8$: explain why their total alone cannot justify the same normal-model claim.

Key: The original probability is supported, but both explanations are incomplete. North's normal population supports its sample mean at $n_N = 12$, and South's $n_S = 48$ supports its sample mean by the CLT. Independence then supports an approximately normal difference, so Rina rejects a supported approximation. Oscar's combined-size rule fails: with $n_N = 48$ and $n_S = 8$, the total is 56, but the small sample from skewed South has no normality justification. The total alone would make readers trust an unsupported tail approximation.

EXIT

One thing the rules box changed about my first take: _____